



Young German men cheer as they march down Pariser Platz in Berlin. Many Germans reacted enthusiastically to being called up for war.



EARLY IN THE YEAR, ATTENTION WAS FOCUSED ON CENTRAL AMERICA.

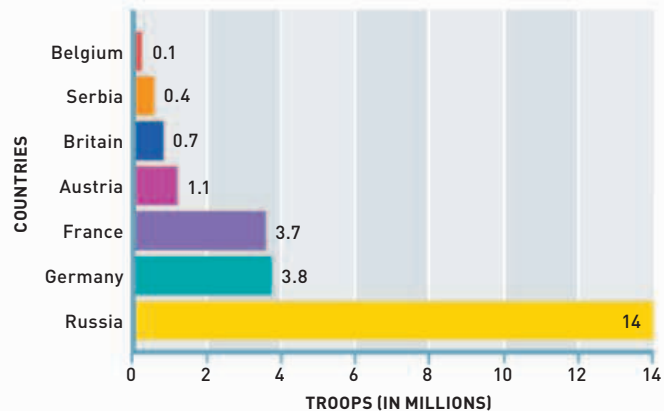
In January, the first ship completed its passage through the **Panama Canal**. This amazing feat of American engineering cost around \$300 million to construct and claimed the lives of around 4,000 workers.

In April, the US intervened in **Mexico's civil war** by sending a force of Marines to **occupy the port of Veracruz**, which prevented President Victoriano Huerta from receiving arms shipments from Germany. The US held the port for six months, contributing to Huerta's fall from power in July.

Meanwhile, Europe began its descent into war. **World War I was sparked** by the assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand (1863–1914), heir to the Austro-Hungarian throne, and his wife Sophie. They were shot on June 28 during an official visit to Sarajevo in Austrian-ruled Bosnia. The fatal shots were fired by 19-year-old Bosnian Serb, Gavrilo Princip.

The Austrian government blamed Serbia for the assassinations. Assured of Germany's full support by Kaiser Wilhelm II (1859–1941), on July 23 the Austrians sent an ultimatum to Serbia. Its demands were intended to be so humiliating that Serbia would reject them, giving the Austrians a pretext for military

Raising the Stars and Stripes
American soldiers raise the flag over the Mexican port of Veracruz. The occupation cost 17 American lives and lasted for six months.



action. Although the Serbians were prepared to make concessions, Austria-Hungary declared war on July 28. In response, Russia began mobilizing its army in support of Serbia.

Within a week, **all the major European powers were at war.** Brushing aside last-minute peace initiatives by Germany's Kaiser Wilhelm and Russia's Czar Nicholas II (1868–1918), German military chiefs insisted that **Germany declare war on Russia.** Since their military plans demanded a swift victory in the west as a prelude to defeating Russia in the east, Germany also **declared war on France.** Germany did not want to fight the British, but in order to invade France they needed to send an army through Belgium, whose neutrality was guaranteed by Britain. On August 4, after German troops had crossed the Belgian frontier, **Britain declared war on Germany.** Although many people privately

Army sizes at the outbreak of war
Russia's army was huge, but it was poorly equipped and badly organized. Britain had a relatively small army, and depended on its navy for defense.

regarded the onset of war with dismay, it was greeted by cheering crowds. The traditionally antimilitarist and internationalist **German Social Democrat Party** rallied to the war effort, convinced Germany had to defend itself against Russian conquest. In France, most previously antimilitarist radicals and socialists adhered to the **union sacrée** (sacred union), which called for a political truce with prowar parties and vetoed any strike action. In the UK, **Ulster Protestant paramilitaries**, who had been on the verge of an armed rebellion against the British government's plans for Irish Home Rule, and their Catholic opponents, the **Irish Volunteers**, volunteered en masse for the British Army.

